

Session 7: Eden Springs in a Dry Land

Key Takeaways

- Faithful to his promises, God blesses Yitskhaq despite his lack of trust.
- In the biblical narrative, God's blessing often becomes a source of jealousy and rivalry between the chosen and the non-chosen characters.
- The biblical authors weave repeated key words like thread, stitching narrative images into thematic tapestries and adding layers of meaning to interconnected stories.

Yitskhaq's Conflict With Abimelech

15 Now, all **the wells** which **his father's servants had dug** in the days of **Abraham his father**, the Philistines had stopped them up, and they had filled them with dust.

16 And Abimelech said to Yitskhaq,
“**Go (הלך)** away from us,
because **you are more powerful** than us!”

17 **And Yitskhaq went (הלך)** from there,
and he camped in the wadi of Gerar,
and he dwelt (**וישב**) there.

18 And Yitskhaq returned (**וישב**)
and he **dug the wells of water**
which had been **dug** in the days of **his father Abraham**,
which the Philistines had stopped up after the death of Abraham,
and he called their names,
the names which his father had called them.

Dispute #1

19 And **Yitskhaq's servants dug** in the wadi,
and they found there **a well of waters of life**,

20 but the herdsmen of Gerar **quarreled (ריב)** with the herdsmen of Yitskhaq, saying,
“The **waters** are ours!”

And he called the name of the well “**Contention (עשק)**”
because they **contended (התעשקו)** with him.

Dispute #2

21 And **they dug another well** ,
and they also **quarreled (ריב)** over it,
and he called its name "Opposition (שטנה)."

Dispute #3

22 And he moved away from there
and he **dug another well** .
And they did not **quarrel (ריב)** over it;
and he called its name "Wide-places (רחבות),"
and he said,
"Because now Yahweh **has widened a place (הרחיב)** for us,
and we will be **fruitful (פרינו)** in the land."

23 **And he went up from there** to **Beersheba (Well of Seven/Oath)**

24 and Yahweh appeared to him that night and said,

"I am the God of **your father Abraham**.

Do not fear, for I am with you,

and **I will bless you**,

and **multiply (הרביתי)** your descendants,

for the sake of **my servant Abraham**."

25 And he built an altar there,

and called upon the name of Yahweh,

and he pitched his tent there,

and there **the servants of Yitskhaq dug a well** .

Genesis 26:15-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

This story is about God's miraculous provision of water from the ground for Yitskhaq in the face of two major obstacles: (1) It's a time of famine (Gen. 26:1), which presumes a drought, and (2) the nations are at odds with God's chosen one through a series of escalating conflicts about access to water.

After we descend from the heights of God's blessing in Genesis 26:1-5 (which recalls the creation blessing of Genesis 1), we now enter the barren deserts of a famine land. But in the middle of the desert, Yitskhaq rediscovers something that the Philistines attempted to stop: access to fresh spring water.

Notice how the design of 26:15-18 highlights the opposition of the Philistines.

A - The **Philistines stopped up** Avraham's wells (Gen. 26:15).

B - **Abimelech banishes** Yitskhaq for fear of his power (Gen. 26:16-17).

A' - Yitskhaq rediscovers Abraham's wells and renames them (Gen. 26:18).

In the face of opposition from the nations, Yitskhaq recovers his father’s wells, and he discovers a new well of “living water” (חיים מים). This is a figure of speech in Hebrew for “running” or “fresh water” (see [Lev. 14:5](#); [Jer. 2:13](#); [Zech. 14:8](#)). As a narrative image, it recalls the key turning point in the story about the creation of Eden.

Genesis 2-3	Genesis 26
Gen. 2:4-7 ⁴ In the day when Yahweh Elohim made the land and skies, ⁵ and no shrub of the field was yet in the land, and no plant of the field had yet sprouted, for Yahweh Elohim had not sent rain upon the land, and there was no human to work the ground, ⁶ but a stream/flow would go up from the land and it would water the whole face of the ground, ⁷ then Yahweh Elohim formed the human of dust from the ground, and he breathed into his nostrils the breath of life ; and the human became a living being.	Gen. 26:1 A time of famine. Gen. 26:15-19 Yitskhaq discovers Abraham’s well, that the Philistines had stopped up with dust . Yitskhaq digs in the dirt for new wells and discovers waters of life .
Gen. 2:18-25 God turns the one human into more than one, by taking flesh and “bone” (עצם) from one of his sides.	Gen. 26:16 Avimelek accuses Yitskhaq of becoming too powerful (עצם) because he has too many people and animals in his camp (see Gen. 26:13).
Gen. 3:21-24 Adam and Eve are banished from Eden.	Gen. 26:16 Avimelek banishes Yitskhaq from his city.
<i>Genesis 2-3 Versus Genesis 26. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Recalling motifs in this way is a common narrative strategy of the biblical authors to show how the current story is walking through the sequence of themes set up in Genesis 1-9. Recalling the motifs in this way also sets our expectations in order to introduce a twist.

Sibling Rivalry and Blessing or Curse

Next, the conflict escalates between Yitskhaq’s shepherds and the Philistine shepherds. This story recalls what happened after the Eden creation story: the failure of Adam and Eve and the rising conflict between rival siblings. This is accomplished by recalling the same theme from the story of Abraham—the conflict between Abraham’s shepherds and Lot’s shepherds.

Genesis 13:2, 5-8 Instructor's Translation

² And Avram was very heavy with herds and with silver and with gold ...

⁵ Now, also belonging to Lot, who went with Avram,
were flocks and cattle and tents ...

⁷ And there was **a dispute between the shepherds of the herd of Avram and between the shepherds of the herd of Lot ...**

⁸ And Avram said to Lot,
“Don’t let there be **disputing between me and between you, between my shepherds and between your shepherds,**
for we men are brothers!”

Genesis 26:14, 19-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁴ and [Yitskhaq] had possessions of flocks
and herds and a great household, and the
Philistines envied him.

¹⁹ And the servants of Yitskhaq dug in the valley
and they found there a well of living water,

²⁰ **and the shepherds of Gerar disputed with the shepherds of Yitskhaq,** saying,

“The water is ours!”

The dispute between the shepherds recalls the exact same scene from the story of Abraham and Lot. In that story, God’s blessing on Abraham that resulted in many possessions is the very thing that creates the conflict among rival family members.

This recalls the motif of Cain and Abel’s sibling rivalry after the banishment from Eden, along with a very subtle clue.

- The very center of the paragraph in Genesis 26:15-25 focuses on the second dispute between the shepherd of Yitskhaq and Philistia. This dispute is singled out by its unique formula that sets it apart from the first and third dispute.
- The second disputed well is named *Sitnah*, that is, “Satan-place” (שטנה). It’s a use of the noun “satan” in its literal sense, “opposition.” And while on the narrative level it simply describes the conflict between rival tribes, it also recalls the important analogy between sin in Genesis 4:7 and the snake in Genesis 3.

A Flood, a Tent, an Altar, and a Blessing

After an extremely subtle walk through the themes of Genesis 1-4, the narrative highlights the rising conflict regarding the wells of water. This is a very subtle recall from the paragraph that described the rising waters of the flood in Genesis 7:17-20.

Genesis 7:17-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁷ And the flood was forty days upon the land,
and the waters were **great** (רבה)
and they lifted up the ark,

and it rose up over the land,

¹⁸ and the waters were **mighty** (גבר)

and they were very **great** (רבה) upon the land,

and the ark went on the face of the waters,

¹⁹ and the waters were **mighty** (גבר), very very much, upon the land,

and they covered all the high mountains which are under the skies, ²⁰ fifteen cubits above,

the waters were **mighty** (גבר),

and they covered the mountains;

The word “mighty” (גבר) is the same Hebrew root of the word “mighty warrior” (גבור) that refers to the Nephilim and also to powerful ancient Near Eastern kings who were violent and volatile (Nimrod in [Gen. 10:8-1](#)). Recall that these Philistine shepherds are servants of King Abimelech of Philistia, who sees Yitskhaq’s presence as a threat to his power. That is, Abimelech is also a *gibbor* (גבור), whose servants are causing a “rising flood” of conflict over the waters!

In the midst of this conflict, God provides for Yitskhaq, who goes off and finds a place of rest associated with the images of Noah’s story during and after the flood.

Genesis 8-9	Genesis 26
Gen. 8:6-10 Noah waits for multiple series of “seven” (שבע) days as the waters recede	Gen. 26:23-25 Yitskhaq goes to “Well of Seven” (באר שבע) and finds water there in the midst of the famine and drought
Gen. 8:20-21 Noah builds an altar	Gen. 26:25 Yitskhaq builds an altar
Gen. 9:1-3 Noah is blessed by God and promised a large family	Gen. 26:24 Yitskhaq is blessed by God and promised a large family
Gen. 9:19-21 Noah sets up a tent in a garden	Gen. 26:25 Yitskhaq sets up his tent at “Well of Seven”
<i>Flood Imagery in Yitskhaq’s Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

This is a not-so-conspicuous recall of the story of Noah after the flood, mirrored in the story of Yitskhaq. But one major theme is absent: The conflict that started the flood is resolved through a covenant. And that’s what the next paragraph of the Yitskhaq story is all about.

Reflection Question

The biblical authors connect each scene in the Genesis scroll to a repeating pattern of themes established in its early chapters. What connections to earlier stories come to mind while studying [Genesis 26:12-25](#)? How do these connections help us meditate on the meaning of this story?